

Open Source Software: Is There an Easy Path to Success?

There's so much that goes on behind the scenes while developing open source software. So how does one make an open source project successful? Is there a shortcut? This article indicates there isn't one.

Open source has become all the rage now. Many entrepreneurs are drawn to it by the allure of quick success. But the truth is, there is no easy path to such success. There is no one thing that you can do to get all of open source right.

In fact, a lot of the challenges that companies face early on are not technology challenges, but are people and cultural challenges.

There are many layers of open source that need to be worked on to build a project that can become a hit in the market. And maintaining that success is an ongoing process. But at the crux of it all lies finding the right answer to a very basic question: what exactly is open source?

Open source is the code

For many new users who may not be fully aware of the layers that make open source, the answer is fairly simple: open source is software!

And that is not wrong, of course, since that is how most of us are using it. But there's just so much more to open source than merely being touted as software.

The essence of any open source project still remains the code. It is what makes the project special and useful for the user. When you're working in open source, the code is just as much a part of the product as the software.

Developing a project from the ground up, or even creating a fork of an existing project, requires thousands and thousands of lines of code to be written, even while handling such a large and complex codebase. Especially in the case of creating a fork, care must be taken to remove any prior licences, marketing material, or anything that might not be useful for the user anymore. After all, it is the features of a project that attract its user base and what retains it. When end users are deciding whether to use open source software, they will read the source code, and what they see there should be something that builds their confidence.

Open source is the community

How you engage with the community is also a part of the task of building a product. Building a community and maintaining a healthy relationship with it is one of the most crucial aspects of open source, but is also often the hardest for most leaders as there is very little one can do to control it. One can try to lay the foundation and can be supportive but, ultimately, it's the people who decide whether they want to join a community.

